

Nikola Bartunkova beats Aryna Sabalenka at China Open

From: BBC Tennis Mined: 2026-10-04 5 min read

Nikola Bartunkova earned a surprise win over world number two Aryna Sabalenka at the China Open, according to a report published on 4 October 2026. The Czech player, ranked 34th in the world, won 6-4, 6-3 and will face Austria's Sinja Kraus next.

Bartunkova said she focused on herself and tried to stay calm during the match. She described Sabalenka as a legend and said she was very happy to have won. The result continued what the report described as Bartunkova's **breakthrough season**.

Sabalenka's defeat came a day after top **seed** Elena Rybakina lost to Armenia's Alina Charaeva, who is ranked 118th. Rybakina had beaten Sabalenka in last month's US Open final and replaced her at the top of the world rankings.

This is the first time since 2015 that the China Open's top two **seeds** have both missed the round of 16. **Seeds** are players given leading positions in a tournament's draw based on their rankings.

Sabalenka had five chances to win a game on Bartunkova's serve, known as **break points**, but did not take any of them. She has now lost six matches in a row in which she lost the **opening set**.

Her most recent titles came in March, when she won Indian Wells and the Miami Open **back-to-back**. Winning both events is known as the "**Sunshine Double**".

Word Treasure

breakthrough season -- A season in which a player makes important progress or achieves notable success.

seed -- A player given a leading position in a tournament's draw based on their ranking.

break point -- A chance to win a game on an opponent's serve.

opening set -- The first set of a match.

back-to-back -- One after the other.

Sunshine Double -- Winning both Indian Wells and the Miami Open.

Background you need

Tournament seeds receive leading positions in the draw based on their rankings.

Break points give a player a chance to win a game on an opponent's serve.

The "Sunshine Double" refers to winning Indian Wells and the Miami Open.

Break it down

The lead reports Bartunkova's surprise victory, the score, her ranking and her next opponent.

Bartunkova's comments explain her approach and reaction, followed by the report's description of her breakthrough season.

Rybakina's defeat provides context about the tournament's leading players and the world rankings.

The article highlights the first time since 2015 that both top seeds have missed the round of 16.

The final paragraphs examine Sabalenka's missed break points, losing run after dropping the opening set and most recent titles.

Why it matters

The 34th-ranked Bartunkova defeated world number two Sabalenka, continuing what the report called her breakthrough season. Together with Rybakina's defeat, the result left both top seeds outside the round of 16 for the first time since 2015.

Test what you remember

1. When was the report about Bartunkova's win published?

- ☐ (A) 4 October 2026
- ☐ (B) 4 October 2015
- ☐ (C) 4 September 2026
- ☐ (D) 4 March 2026

2. What was Bartunkova's world ranking?

- ☐ (A) Second
- ☐ (B) 118th
- ☐ (C) First
- ☐ (D) 34th

3. Who defeated top seed Elena Rybakina at the China Open?

- ☐ (A) World number two Aryna Sabalenka
- ☐ (B) Armenia's Alina Charaeva
- ☐ (C) Czech player Nikola Bartunkova
- ☐ (D) Austria's Sinja Kraus

4. What had Rybakina done in last month's US Open final?

- ☐ (A) Lost to Alina Charaeva
- ☐ (B) Lost to Bartunkova
- ☐ (C) Beaten Sabalenka
- ☐ (D) Beaten Sinja Kraus

5. What happened at the China Open for the first time since 2015?

- ☐ (A) Sabalenka won the Sunshine Double
- ☐ (B) Bartunkova became world number one
- ☐ (C) Charaeva became the top seed
- ☐ (D) Both top seeds missed the round of 16

6. Which losing run does the article describe for Sabalenka?

- ☐ (A) Six matches in a row in which she lost the opening set
- ☐ (B) Five matches in which she won the opening set
- ☐ (C) Six China Open finals in a row
- ☐ (D) Five matches against Bartunkova

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: D 3: B 4: C 5: D 6: A

Questions to think about

1. **Nikola Bartunkova:** She credited her focus on herself and efforts to stay calm, described Sabalenka as a legend and said she was very happy to win.
2. **The report:** It presented the result as a surprise and as part of Bartunkova's breakthrough season.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):